

fridayReview

THE HINDU

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THE CHANGEMAKER CALLED U. SHRINIVAS

The mandolin maestro reimagined Carnatic music with a western instrument **p4**

Subha J Rao

It's way past 10 p.m., and the Kadri *jaathre* (mela) is on in Mangaluru, Karnataka. There's a nip in the January air, and people walk into the more-than-1,000-year-old illuminated Manjunatha temple painted a vivid blue. Suddenly, there's an echo of percussion sounds – the night's Yakshagana has begun. People take their seats as Shri Sai Kala Yaksha Balaga, Dr Shivarama Karantha Balavana Puthur, a primarily women-led troupe headed by Prema Kishor, starts the four-hour-long Rati Kalyana performance.

The voices reach a crescendo, the dancers jump and spin, and people watch mesmerised. The next morning, their elaborate costumes packed and oil-based make-up washed off, they get back to routine. They can be homemakers, teachers, students and dancers, all drawn to Yakshagana because of its larger-than-life appeal and cultural connect.

This was not the case some decades ago, when Yakshagana was a male bastion, with the men donning female roles too. Women entered the field sometime in the mid-19th century, notes banker, Yakshagana exponent and writer Krishna Prakasha Ulithaya. "There's not much documentation, but there's reference to a Kibbacchala Manjamma, from Sagar in Shivamogga district, who lived from 1830 to 1900 and wrote four or five plays, including Sampoorana Mahitrya and Jeeva Paramara Kalyana. There's also a reference to a Mahalakshmi Hebbara Chavady, who wrote Kempasura Kalaga. But women entered the performance space very recently," he says.

Narmada Shibarooraya was the first female bhagavatha (singer), but she remained an amateur artiste. Leelavathi Baipadittaya was the first professional female artiste, starting her career in 1970. Her husband Harinarayana Baipadittaya, a senior Yakshagana percussionist, scholar and teacher taught her Yakshagana singing, Ulithaya elaborates.

Among the emerging young performers is Sakshi Sheshadri, 20, a final year student of business at St. Aloysius, Mangaluru. She was hardly three when she watched a Yakshagana performance. In the

International Women's Day - March 8

Role REVERSAL

Once a male bastion, Yakshagana now has many all-women troupes that perform through the night



evening, during the Yakshagana season (November-April), she dons heavy costumes, paints her face in myriad colours and performs Yakshagana. One day, she's god, the other day an asura, and the third, a female dancer.

"I remember artistes had arrived at our home in Kateel for a performance. Everyone thought a child would be afraid of the exaggerated expressions. But I apparently smiled. My father Sheshadri P Bhat decided I would learn the art form," she says.

She began learning when in Class 3. Her first performance was in front of Goddess Durga Parameshwari in Kateel. In class six, she moved to Urva, in Mangaluru, to learn under Sumangala Ratnakar Rao. "When I began learning, there was a mix of excitement and fear. My Kannada was not very strong then and I did not have any dialogues. I learnt with time."

Arathi Patrame, 43, began learning during school in Nidle, near Dharmasthala. "I think I was attracted to the costume. Not many women learnt the art form then, and Venkatesh Tulupule, our school teacher who was an amateur artiste, taught us the basics to prepare us for the annual day. I played Daksha." Arathi later moved to Ujire and was mentored by artistes Ashok Bhat Ujire and Surikumeru Govinda Bhat K. Arathi balances her passion of Yakshagana with teaching English at Vidyanithi PU College in Tumakuru. She trains students in Yakshagana at Yakshadeevige, with her husband Padmanabha K.V., an associate

professor at Tumkur University. They went to Bhutan recently on a project granted by India Bhutan Foundation, for a comparative study on the mask dance of Bhutan and India's Yakshagana.

Poornima Yatheesha Rai, 51, has been performing Yakshagana since the age of 14. She began in 1988 with a show of Punyakoti, the story of the honest cow that went back to offer herself to the hungry tiger. "I had the support of my brother Madhav Shetty Bana, and learnt from guru Shivram Panambur and Ramesh Shetty



Breaking barriers Many young women are undergoing training in this theatrical art form, which is performed both in temples and on stage. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Bayaru." Her troupe Shri Mahaganapathe Mahila Yakshangana Sangha in Bala Katipalla, near Mangaluru, has staged more than 1,500 performances across the country and in Dubai, some of them night-long."

Sridhara Aithal, a banker, was the first to teach Thenkutittu (southern style) Yakshangana to women, says Sumangala, 49, a trained Bharatanatyam artiste. She began learning Yakshagana in 2009 at the age of 32 from Rakesh Rai Adka, a Yakshagana artiste. Her first performance was Krishnarjuna Kalaga, where she played Arjuna.

What Sumangala has done is introduce the structured learning of Bharatanatyam to Yakshagana training. "Earlier, many learnt for a programme or an event; now they learn it as an art form with its nuances. At Yaksharadhana Kala Kendra, which Sumangala launched in 2009, she teaches about 30 students the eight basic steps, and balancing techniques to handle the heavy costume and headgear." She feels Bharatanatyam has added grace to her Yakshangana moves. Ironically, most women artistes are known for their male roles. Poornima is known for her Kamsa, Mahisasura and Arjuna portrayals, while Sumangala's Krishna is hugely popular. Her Devi, Sathyabhama and Dakshayini also draw in the crowds. Sumangala imagines a day when male and female Yakshagana artistes are treated with the same respect, and both help the other better their craft. With more women entering the space, there have been some changes - primarily separate changing rooms and restrooms.

The women in Yakshagana say that they feel closer to the land of their origin when they ascend the stage. "Performing Yakshagana has given a purpose to my life, as I carry forward a legacy," says Sumangala.

Offbeat

How Amirthavarshini, the 18-year-old thavil artiste, challenges stereotypes

Deepa Venkatraman

From playing the thavil in the temples of Mannargudi near Thanjavur as a schoolgirl to joining A.R. Rahman's 'Wonderment Tour' concert in Chennai recently, Amirthavarshini Manishankar's musical journey seems like a fairy tale. But in reality, it is also a story of conviction and perseverance – of a young girl carving a space for herself as a thavil artiste in the male-dominated world of Carnatic percussion.

"I was both excited and emotional when Rahman sir asked me to play an avarthanam at the 'Wonderment Tour' concert. Performing solo in front of a huge audience was a dream come true," says Amrithavarshini. The 18-year-old recalls how she got

the opportunity, "It felt surreal when Rahman sir began following me on Instagram last October. A little later, his manager called to say that I needed to be in Chennai for two days in February to be part of the concert."

Hailing from a family of musicians, Amirthavarshini grew up listening to her father, nagaswaram artiste A.P. Manishankar, and violinist-mother G. Jayanthi Shankar, who often performed during rituals and festivals in temples. A decade ago, when she was just eight, Amrithavarshini defied convention by choosing to learn the thavil – an instrument rarely pursued by women. "I once asked my parents why there were no women thavil artistes. They said the instrument is heavy and the posture required to play it is difficult. After hearing that, I became even



more determined to take it up," she says.

Though many were sceptical about her decision, her elder brother Manoj Kumar – who passed away a few years ago – stood firmly by her side. "I always pray to

him before every concert," she says.

Amirthavarshini was the first female student of Adhichaburam A.B. Ramadhass. She later came under the tutelage of Kovilur K.G. Kalyana Sundaram. She

Defying gender norms
Amirthavarshini Manishankar. PHOTO: J. JOHAN SATHYADAS

now continues her advanced training, particularly to hone her manodharma skills, under veteran thavil artiste Thanjavur T.R. Govindharajan.

On her guru's advice, Amrithavarshini began playing the thavil by resting the instrument on her lap instead of placing it on the floor. "This is not easy given its weight of nearly 60 kg. Playing it for long hours requires immense stamina and often results in pain in the shoulder and legs. At times, my fingers bleed, taking up to 10 days to heal. Before a concert, I wrap a tape around my fingers and apply glue to secure the caps that produce the sound. Thankfully, modern audio systems have made performing a little easier now, as the amplified sound output has reduced physical strain," she explains.

Amrithavarshini's maiden public performance at the age of 11 was at the Arulmigu Muthumairamman Temple in Arudhwarangalam. "The temple trustee S.N.S. Narayanaswamy, had come

home to invite my parents to the annual panguni festival. Watching me practice, he asked if I would perform with them. I agreed and played a simple avarthanam."

Amrithavarshini has accompanied leading artistes across genres, including violinist A. Kanyakumari, flautist Sikkil Mala Chandrasekar, drums Sivamani and singer Daler Mehndi.

Amrithavarshini is gearing up for her next musical outing – this time, as part of an all-women percussion ensemble called 'Women Who Drum', which will perform at The Mahindra Percussion Festival this weekend in Bengaluru. "I am excited to share the stage with established artistes," she says.

In her effort to get more



The thavil should not be viewed merely as an instrument — it is a sacred responsibility, a commitment to carrying forward our tradition.

AMIRTHAVARSHINI MANISHANKAR

women to play the thavil, Amrithavarshini has begun guiding young girls interested in playing the instrument. "Currently, I am focussing on workshops rather than conducting regular classes, as I am pursuing degrees in law and music. I am also compiling a reference book on korvais exclusively for thavil learners," says Amrithavarshini.

In July 2025, she launched Yuva Thaal Tharang (YTT), an ensemble that features thavil, violin, mridangam, kanjira, ghatam and the saxophone. Featuring both all-women and mixed groups, YTT has presented more than 50 concerts across India, making its debut at the Kerala Sangeetha Nataka Akademi. "The aim was to make the thavil a lead rhythm instrument. The response has been quite encouraging," she says.

Her message to aspiring women percussionists is clear and heartfelt: "Discipline, dedication, consistency and passion are essential. But above all, you must be strong-willed. The thavil should not be viewed merely as an instrument – it is a sacred responsibility, a commitment to carrying forward our tradition."



Musical synergy Sandeep Narayan, Trichy Sankaran on the mridangam, V.V.S. Murari on the violin and K.V. Gopalakrishnan on the kanjira.
PHOTO: S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

P Srihari

Even before the first note was sung, the atmosphere at the packed Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan felt momentous. It was a concert organised by MadRasana at the behest of veteran mridangist Trichy Sankaran, featuring vocalist Sandeep Narayan along with V.V.S. Murari on the violin and K.V. Gopalakrishnan on the kanjira. It was no surprise to see the octogenarian maestro himself seated behind the mridangam, setting the stage for an evening charged with anticipation.

Sandeep seized the moment by making an astute kriti choice: Tyagaraja's 'Nada tanum anisam sankaram' – a tribute to both the Lord and the maestro. His solemn rendition of the kriti, in Chittaranjani, set the tone for the recital that was markedly restrained, yet resonant.

Jaganmohini raga was outlined next and, sure enough, 'Sobillu saptaswara' ensued. Sandeep capped the song with a nuanced swarakalpana at the pallavi opening. While the forays were pleasing throughout the expansive segment, those in the upper registers were particularly bright. Murari's violin responses matched the vocalist's singing both in style and substance.

Even as one wondered whether the evening's theme was a tribute to music itself, the mind skimmed through the likes of 'Nadopasana', 'Mokshamu galada',

A raga-rhythm dialogue

Trichy Sankaran displayed the fine art of accompaniment at Sandeep Narayan's concert



'Nadaloludai' and 'Swaraga sudharasa' as possible kritis to follow. That cue was set aside with Sandeep embarking on Hussemi alapana. The raga is at once folksy and classical, delicate yet weighty. This duality was captured in the initial and

final phrases, and the melody blossomed through a series of tender swirls and languid exploration in between.

Then came a shift in the mood. Sandeep stated that Sankaran's migration to Toronto five decades ago had

deprived Chennai rasikas of his presence throughout the year as he performed here only during the Season. Drawing a parallel from Arunachala Kavi's 'Ramanatakam', he presented 'Eppadi manam tunindado swami' (Misra Chapu) – the moment where Sita bemoans Rama's departure to the forests without her, asking, 'how did your mind become so daring, Lord?' The comparison sent ripples through the audience. Sandeep's rendition in the right tempo underscored the melancholy.

Swati Tirunal's 'Bhogindra sayinam', in Kuntalavarali set to Khanda Chapu, followed with a sprightly swarakalpana passage, providing an ideal contrast.

Thodi served as the centrepiece, with the raga unfurled in three well-proportioned phases. Sandeep's elaborate phrases in madhya sthayi were sublime, while the brisk sancharas took the exploration to a crescendo.

In the final segment, he seamlessly incorporated a grahabhedam (ri) to derive Mohanakalyani before closing out Thodi.

Murari's solo was fluent and well-structured across the phases. Papanasam Sivan's 'Karthikeya gangeya' is a classic, both lyrically and melodically. Sandeep's niraval and swara passages at the charanam opening, 'Maal maruga', were engaging, with the ensemble providing fine synergy.

A word about the master percussionist. With over six decades of concert experience, Sankaran demonstrated that playing for a kriti is never mere accompaniment, but a refined musical dialogue that elevates the entire performance. It is a style that blends imagination with sensitivity to enhance the vocalist's artistry. Sankaran's elaborate tani avartanam in two-kalai Adi tala was woven around intriguing patterns and subtle variations. The master's deft touch and deceptive speed were on full display, and he was admirably complemented by Gopalakrishnan, whose kanjira playing lent vibrant support all through the concert.

'Kanden kamazh tharu konrai', a verse from Thirumoolar's 'Thirumandiram', was sung as a virutham in Behag, leading into Gopalakrishna Bharathi's 'Irakkam varamal ponadhenna'. A shloka, 'Venkatadri samam sthanam' in Sindhubhairavi, followed by Purandaradasar's 'Venkatachala nilayam' concluded the recital.

Layered with bhava

Anjali Hariharan explored the many shades of bhakti through a thoughtfully curated repertoire

Srividya

Anjali Hariharan, a senior disciple of Anita Guha, presented a bhava-rich recital, at Narada Gana Sabha mini hall recently.

She began her performance, for Natyarangam, with an energetic nritya piece, set to tune by Venkateshwaran Kuppuswamy. This was followed by a keerthanam 'Shringara lahari', composed by Lingaraj extolling goddess Mathangi, in raga Nilambari. The keerthanam describes the goddess as an embodiment of compassion and grace.

A composition by the Thanjavur Quartet 'Karuna juda', a varnam in raga Atana, tala Adi, was taken up next. The kriti is about a viraha

nayika who expresses her deep longing to unite with the lord of Thanjavur. However, the bhakti rasa, predominant in the piece, added beauty to the depiction.

The choreographer's (Anitha Guha) expertise was evident in the handling of the sancharis – her interpretation of the ceremonial procession of the deity, wherein Anjali took on multiple roles such as the awestruck devotee, the men carrying the idol and the majestic appearance of the lord

The nritya interludes in the varnam, marked by sparkling footwork that included sutradavu or bhramaris, aptly brought out the dynamic persona of Brahadeeswara.

The multiple dimensions of Meera's bhakti to Krishna were captured effectively in the bhajan



Anjali Hariharan.
PHOTO: S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

'Hari bin savaan kyon aaye' in raga Madhuvanthi, Misra Chapu tala, set to tune by Prof. V.V. Subrahmanyam. Meera dreams about dancing with Krishna, as she experiences the beautiful showers of savaan, when the cuckoo sings and the peacock dances joyously. Suddenly she realises that Krishna is not with her. It is in this moment that she laments: 'Without you Hari, all this beauty is incomplete'.

Anjali's portrayal of devotion and unwavering love of Meera for Krishna reflected a high degree of spiritual and emotional refinement. The thillana by Lalgudi Jayaraman in raga Mohanakalyani, and tala Adi, was performed with grace.

The recital concluded with 'Hariharathamajam' that had the intended calming effect.

Anitha Guha's choreographic pieces, crafted specially for Anjali, was in tune with the lyrical and emotional content of the songs. The orchestra, with Jayashree Ramanathan (nattuvangam), Hariprasad Kaniyal (vocals), Ramshankar Babu (mridangam), Anantha Raman (violin) and Sujit Naik(flute) added value to the performance.

The power of silence

Kruthika Thyagarajan chose popular kritis for 'Mounam'

V.V. Ramani

Day two of the Jharna festival, presented by Kaladham Charitable Trust, held at SPASTIN TEACH auditorium, featured Kruthika Thyagarajan. She began her recital with a jathiswaram in raga kapi. This was followed by 'Sringapuradeeshwari sharadhe', a composition by Padmacharan in raga Kalyani. Choreographed by guru P. Bhanumathi, the piece was an ode to Saraswathi. Her nritya and abhinaya were testimony to the dancer's skill and training.

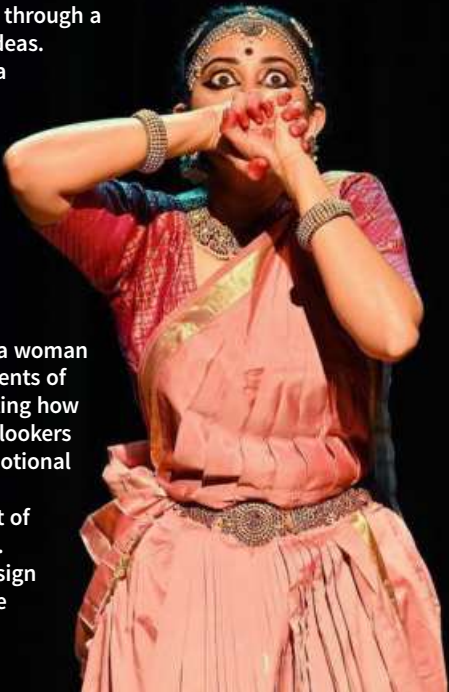
Kruthika, drawing from a deeply personal space, explored the power of silence in 'Mounam'. The work examined the conflict between inner turmoil and outward composure through a range of evocative ideas. Anchored in Sringara rasa, the piece used songs such as 'Kandalal mudhalai' and 'Idhaivida innum vendumo satchi' to trace the many shades of love.

'Mounam' also confronted the fear a woman experiences in moments of assault. By highlighting how the silent gaze of onlookers can intensify her emotional distress, Kruthika conveyed the weight of unspoken judgment. Effective lighting design further amplified the work's emotional intensity, especially

during sequences that depicted fear. 'Mounam' featured popular kritis from the Bharatanatyam repertoire, supported by a sensitive musical score by Rohit Bhat Upoor. The carefully crafted soundscape effectively captured the impact of silence. However, there were moments when the adavus and jathikorvais felt out of sync with the emotional tone, diluting the overall mood of the piece.

While the concept resonated on multiple levels, the work would have benefitted from a more seamless integration of its various segments.

Intense Kruthika Thyagarajan..
PHOTO: B. VELANKANNI RAJ



On a spiritual quest

Navyasree K.N.'s performance showed how a devotee's pilgrimage to Tirumala is both a physical and emotional journey

V.V. Ramani

The creative guidelines offered by Jharna, the annual dance festival, are meant to inspire young dancers to venture beyond traditional vocabulary and explore fresh concepts. Yet, Navyashree K. N., working with a theme steeped in devotion, chose to remain firmly within the classical framework for her presentation of 'Venkatesha Shreesha'.

Her narrative followed a devotee's ascent up the seven sacred hills of Tirumala, interweaving the physicality of the pilgrimage with the inner stirrings of surrender and faith. The journey culminated in the sanctum sanctorum, where the darshan of the Lord becomes a moment of liberation for the devotee.

From the outset, the unhurried pace of her dance established a meditative mood. The opening piece – a jathiswaram in raga Abhogi choreographed by Praveen Kumar – was noteworthy for the clarity of each adavu and

overall grace in movements.

The thematic core was shaped musically by weaving together select pasurams of the Azhwars in the format of a Sabdham. These verses vividly described the beauty of Lord Venkateshwara and the temple. A concluding Devarnama, 'Ninna divya moorthiya', set to ragamalika and talamalika, further enriched the spiritual experience. The musical score for the evening was composed by Eshwar Iyer.

The idea of aligning the seven hills with the seven chakras of the body was intriguing, though it felt like a concept that could have been explored with greater depth.

Nevertheless, the detailing that Navyashree brought – whether in describing the landscape or capturing the shifting emotions of the devotee – elevated the performance's overall sublimity.

The final moment of darshan that she portrayed was particularly striking, rendered even more poignant by two diagonal streaks of light that enveloped the dancer.



High on bhakti Navyashree K.N.
PHOTO: M. SRINATH



Chitra Swaminathan
chitra.swaminathan@thehindu.co.in

Tribute festivals serve a deeper purpose than merely reviving memories. They offer a moment to pause and reflect on how an artiste has shaped the musical landscape, why their works continue to endure and what aspects of their artistry are worth emulating. ‘The GREATMANDolin’ show on March 6 (6 p.m.) at The Music Academy is one such reminder of the extraordinary journey of the child prodigy mandolin U. Shrinivas.

With a Western instrument in his hands, Shrinivas reimagined the contours of Carnatic music, crafting a sound that was entirely his own. More than 12 years after his passing, his music continues to find fresh expressions. A recent example is the 2025 Grammy nomination for Shakti’s ‘Shrini’s Dream’, a track composed in his honour by long-time friends and collaborators Ustad Zakir Hussain, John McLaughlin, Selva Ganesh, Ganesh Rajagopalan and Shankar Mahadevan.

“‘The GREATMANDolin’ is not just an ode to a young maestro, the annual tribute concert is a way to celebrate my brother’s ability to achieve equal success as a soloist and as a member of global



ensembles. Even today, I am amazed at how, without indulging in compulsive experimentation, he constantly expanded the horizons of his music. I often wonder if, in the brief span of his life, he ever realised how profoundly he gave the mandolin a new character and tonal colour. Whether at home, on stage or at public gatherings, he spoke very little because his music did all the talking,” says mandolin exponent U. Rajesh, seated in the very room at his Vadapalani home in Chennai where Shrinivas spent time practising and composing.

“It’s never easy to put a musical show together,” adds Rajesh, “but it’s always exciting to work on ‘The GREATMANDolin’. Over the years, everyone we’ve invited has been eager to join. As tabla legend Ustad Zakir Hussain used to say,

‘Shrinivas wins hearts with just his innocent, childlike smile.’ That’s the image people still carry of him.”

Shrinivas’ mandolin was a bridge between East and West, between the past and future, between the known and the newly possible. It is this blend that renowned Carnatic vocalist, author and social activist T.M. Krishna captures with rare clarity when he speaks about Shrinivas. “He brought a completely new instrument into the world of Carnatic music. Though we called it mandolin, it was more accurately an electric mini-guitar. Shrinivas didn’t just adapt the instrument – he created an entirely new vocabulary for it, one that could express the grandeur and complexity of Carnatic music. He drew from both instrumental

and vocal traditions, yet what emerged was unmistakably his own. When he played Kalyani, it was Shrinivas’ Kalyani,” says Krishna, who will headline ‘The GREATMANDolin’ show.

Carnatic music is inherently vocal-centric, and carving out a space as an instrumentalist is incredibly difficult. “But Shrinivas managed to,” Krishna points out.



In the 1980s, when amplified instruments were still unfamiliar in this space, this young boy brought the sound of the electric mandolin into a centuries-old tradition.

T.M. KRISHNA

▶ **Stringed legacy** U. Shrinivas and (below) with John McLaughlin, Ustad Zakir Hussain and V. Selvaganesh at a concert at The Music Academy in 2007. PHOTOS: BHARGAVI MANI AND S.S. KUMAR

“In the 1980s, when amplified instruments were still unfamiliar in this space, this young boy introduced the sound of the electric mandolin into a centuries-old tradition. And he achieved it all as an outsider. He did not belong to the core Carnatic world of Chennai. He came from a different social and cultural background. Only someone with a rare combination of talent, imagination and conviction could have done it.”

Shrinivas began playing the mandolin at the age of six. Though initially hesitant, his father, a clarinet artiste, at the insistence of friends allowed him to pursue it. Soon, the sight of the frail little boy with a mandolin in hand became familiar at concerts. Senior musicians accompanied him with pride, recognising early the depth of his vidwat.

“It wasn’t just his skill, he won over audiences and fellow artistes with his pleasing demeanour and humility. He was an ever-giving guru. Though I worked in cinema, that never bothered him; he was always willing to guide and support me. He would happily introduce me to the musicians and music lovers who came backstage to meet him after concerts. ‘The GREATMANDolin’ show is a reminder that art is always higher than the individual,” says popular music director Devi Sri Prasad, who has been part of the show since its inception.

An integral part of the pioneering multi-genre band Shakti, Shrinivas became a favourite of the Ustad, who had founded the ensemble alongside jazz virtuoso John McLaughlin. With both maestros now gone, one realises how their music continues to remain alive – not merely for the brilliance of their performances, but for the warmth of their personalities and the accessibility of their art.

‘The GREATMANDolin’ also features Anil Srinivasan, Anna Rakita, Harmeet Manseta, Siddharth Nagarajan, Steven Samuel Devassy and Praveen Narayanan.

CALENDAR

Music concerts

Hamsadhvani will feature the following programmes at Youth Hostel, Adyar, as part of its 36th annual festival. Today, 6.15 p.m.: Delhi Sunderrajan (vocal) with V.V. Ravi on the violin, Neyveli Narayanan on the mridangam and K.V. Gopalakrishnan on the kanjira.

March 7, 6.15 p.m.: A special concert to mark International Women’s Day, titled ‘Women Trinity and Icons’ will feature performances by Saindhavi, Vidya Kalyanaraman and Vinaya Karthik with Rangapriya (violin), Bharat Damodaran (keyboards), Venkatasubramaniam (tabla), and Shrihari (percussion).

Celebrating women

The Music Academy will feature the vocal concert by Bharathi Ramasubban on March 9, 6 p.m. at the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall. She will be accompanied by Shreya Devnath (violin) and Ranjani Siddanthi Venkatesh (mridangam). Featuring only women artistes, the programme is organised under the endowment instituted by Dr. N. Rajalakshmi, to commemorate International Women’s Day.

Tyagaraja aradhana

Shakthi Sangita Sabha will celebrate Tyagaraja aradhana on March 8 at Shakthi Palace, Anbu Nagar, from 8.30 a.m. to 11.30 a.m. Chanting of Sri Vishnu Sahasranamam; and presentation of Pancharatna kritis and Utsava Sampradaya kritis will form part of the event.

Award of Excellence

Maharajapuram Viswanatha Iyer Trust and Maharajapuram Santhanam Foundation have jointly organised the annual awards function which will take place today, 5 p.m. at Vani Mahal, T. Nagar. Maharajapuram Viswanatha Iyer Memorial Award for ‘Pakkavadhyam Excellence’ will be conferred upon senior violinist Nagai Muralidharan. Vocalist R.K. Padmanabha will receive the Acharya award. The Youth Excellence Award will be presented to ghatam artiste Sarvesh Karthick. The Maharajapuram Santhanam Memorial Award will be given to senior mridangist Yella Venkateshwara Rao. The Meritorious Awards of Excellence goes to Sikkil Gurucharan, K. Gayatri and Trichy Krishnaswamy. Cleveland V.V. Sundaram will preside and present the awards. The evening also features Trichy Kalyanaraman’s discourse at 6.30 p.m.

Srividya Ganesan, K. Gayatri, J. Swagath and Vijayagopal will perform On March 7 at Ganamritha Hall, Sambandam Street, Mandaveli.

Special moment

Members of the Mridanga Baghavathi Trust of guru Karaikudi Mani have made the exponent’s dream come true by presenting a golden mridangam to the Mridanga Saileswari temple at Muzhakunnu, in Kannur district, Kerala. The event took place on February 22.

S.K. Srinivasan and K. Usha presented the swarna mridangam, which was received by O.K. Vasu master, president, Malabar Devaswom Board, on behalf of the temple. T.J. Biju, commissioner, Malabar Devaswom Board; P.K. Madusoodanan, chairman, Maramath standing committee; and M. Manoharan, executive officer, Mridanga Saileshwari temple, were among those present on the occasion. This was followed by a vocal concert and tani avarthanam presentation by guru Kariakudi Mani’s disciples, who had travelled from various parts of India.

Showcase of talent

Narada Gana Sabha Trust will feature the following concerts at its mini hall, on March 11: 5.30 p.m.: Amrithavarshini (vocal) and 7 p.m.: Aditya Sridhar.

New play

Under the auspices of Chromepet Cultural Academy, T.K.S. Nadaga Mandram will stage *Avvai Dasan*, a Tamil play on March 7, 6.30 p.m. at its venue.

Bombay Chanakya’s return

After a seven-year hiatus, well-known theatre director Bombay Chanakya makes a comeback to stage with a new Tamil play *Maathru Devo Bhava*, to be premiered on March 13 (Kartik Fine Arts) with an encore on March 14 (Narada Gana Sabha).

The drama traces the trials, tribulations, and sacrifices of a mother while raising her children. The story is said to be based on the the life of producer J. Balasubramanian’s mother. The title song and background score are composed by senior violinist Lalgudi G.J.R. Krishnan, lyrics by Ashwin Kumar Iyer with R.P. Sharavan and Vijayashri rendering the songs.

Venue: Narada Gana Sabha. Time: 6:45 p.m.

Thrisathi homam

Sri Kamakshi Mandali Trust will conduct the Chathru Samhara Sri Subramania Thrisathi homam for 108 days from March 9 to June 24, at Sri Sankara Math, West Mambalam. Special pujas, japam, Chandi parayanam and chanting of Lalitha Sahasranamam will be performed daily from 4 p.m. to 8.30 p.m.



Anand Seshadri’s Beethoven 32 Project promises to be less a series of concerts and more an evolving conversation

Rachel Rhine

Anand Seshadri’s recital at the Museum Theatre marked not just a concert, but the beginning of his *Beethoven 32 Project* – an extended undertaking to perform the composer’s complete piano sonatas over the coming years. Rather than announcing the ambition with grand rhetoric, he allowed the idea to reveal itself through music and reflection. The recital felt less like a launch and more like the opening page of a book.

Designed as a lecture-recital, the programme moved between explanation and performance. Trained in the UK, the U.S., Hungary and Germany, Anand Seshadri brings to his performances a dual perspective shaped by concert practice and composition. Before each work, he briefly outlined structural ideas, tracing how motifs evolve and how emotional momentum accumulates across movements. These spoken moments altered the audience’s listening posture. One began to hear transitions more actively, anticipating shifts in harmony or texture that might otherwise pass unnoticed.

Anand prefers the term ‘Art Music’ to the more familiar ‘Western classical music’, describing it as a continuum that connects works across centuries rather than a fixed historical

On a grand sonata quest

category. In conversation after the recital, he observed that Chennai audiences, shaped by deep philosophical and musical traditions, respond strongly when performances offer intellectual engagement alongside aesthetic experience. “People don’t just want to hear a piano,” he said. “They want to experience a journey.”

The programme opened with

Johannes Brahms’ *Intermezzi*, Op.117 (Nos.1 and 3), music often described as autumnal reflections. Anand approached them with restraint, allowing phrases to unfold without rhetorical exaggeration. The sound world he created emphasised inwardness rather than outward drama. The Ballade in G minor, Op.118 No.3, introduced a darker emotional

▶ **Hitting the right note**
Anand Seshadri.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

register, its rhythmic firmness balanced by carefully shaped melodic lines.

Franz Schubert’s ‘Impromptu’ in C minor extended the contemplative atmosphere. Having explained the work’s structural flow beforehand, Anand allowed repetition to function as a transformation rather than a recurrence. Technical assurance remained evident, but it never dominated the musical narrative.

After the interval came Beethoven’s *Appassionata* Sonata, Op.57, the centrepiece of the evening. Anand has lived with Beethoven’s sonatas for over 15 fifteen years, and he describes undertaking the complete cycle now as an opportunity to “grow with the music over the coming decade. Each sonata teaches something different, both as a performer and as a composer.”

Often referred to as the ‘New Testament’ of piano literature, the 32 sonatas chart Beethoven’s artistic evolution. Anand spoke of how the early works foreground virtuosity, the middle-period sonatas demand a deeper synthesis of technique and musical insight, while the late works require an expanded imagination of sound and colour. The cumulative demands, he noted, are what make the cycle



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ANAND SESHADRI

intellectually and physically formidable: no single sonata can stand in for the whole.

His interpretation of the *Appassionata* reflected this long view. The opening movement carried contained volatility rather than overt aggression, its tensions unfolding with architectural clarity. Anand describes the work as a “passionate musical hurricane,” yet his performance emphasised control and emotional continuity.

The recital concluded with Kaleidoscope Reflection, one of Anand’s original compositions. Positioned after Beethoven, the work functioned as a contemporary reflection rather than a stylistic contrast. Shifting textures and harmonic colours suggested an artiste actively absorbing historical influence while speaking in a personal voice. Anand describes his dual identity as pianist and composer as mutually sustaining: analysing Beethoven’s musical ‘DNA’ informs interpretation, while performing the sonatas deepens his understanding of the piano’s physical and expressive possibilities as a composer. He says, “On stage even a 200-year-old sonata should feel like a premiere.”

In Chennai’s evolving cultural landscape, such projects signal a quiet expansion of listening cultures. Western art music occupies a smaller but increasingly curious space within the city’s classical ecosystem. By combining performance with explanation, Anand’s lecture-recital format lowers entry barriers without simplifying complexity, inviting audiences into the act of listening rather than positioning them as passive observers.

If the *Beethoven 32 Project* continues in this spirit, it promises to be less a series of concerts than an evolving conversation.